



ASSEMBLYMEMBER Matt Haney, right, tours the L.A. Fashion District last month with the district's chief executive, Anthony Rodriguez. Haney plans to introduce legislation next year to help downtowns in the state.

As downtowns struggle, seeking paths to revival

Lawmaker tours state's ailing urban cores to find answers

By THOMAS CURWEN

The sidewalks of the Fashion District in downtown Los Angeles were bustling. Silver-faced, tuxedoed mannequins stared down crazy clowns and beaming Hello Kittys. Ball caps, Stetsons and sombreros, baby strollers, toasters and Crock-Pots, lucha libre masks, belts and shoes burst from open storefronts and vendors' sidewalk card tables. Steam rose from food trucks and carts.

Matt Haney, a Democratic Assembly member from San Francisco, did a weave and a bob as he navigated the narrow straits.



COVID shutdowns greatly affected downtowns, many of which are still struggling almost five years later.

Dressed in denim and a monogrammed windbreaker, cradling a cup of coffee, he was casual and unassuming, perfectly attired for fact-finding on a late fall morning.

"Like all of you, I love downtowns, and I, like all of you, will not accept that we give up on our downtowns," he had told L.A. business leaders earlier in the day. "They are too important. They impact people's lives in so many positive ways."

Los Angeles was one of nine stops on his tour of the state's downtowns.

From Sacramento to San Diego, he's in search of a prescription for California's ailing urban cores.

California population is growing again

The state added 232,570 residents this year. Its total is near pre-pandemic level.

By JENNY JARVIE

After several years of decline, California's population grew by almost a quarter of a million residents in 2024, according to the U.S. Census Bureau, a rebound that brings the Golden State almost back to its pre-pandemic numbers.

The numbers are not all

rosy. California experienced a slower growth rate than the country as a whole, particularly large states in the fast-growing South. It also experienced the nation's largest domestic migration loss.

But experts say California's new population figures represent an important turnaround.

"The big picture is California is growing again," said Hans Johnson, a senior fellow at the Public Policy Institute of California. "It shows California has a pretty healthy growth rate. ... The number of people who are com-

ing into the state from abroad has increased, the number of people leaving for other states has decreased. There are still substantial flows to other states, but that's not as large as it was."

Although California's population gain of 232,570 people from July 1, 2023, to July 1, 2024, represents the largest numeric population increase in the nation's West, it lagged behind Texas, where the population expanded by 562,941, and Florida, which grew by 467,347 people.

California's 0.6% population increase also fell short

of the national average (0.9%) and was significantly outpaced by the District of Columbia (2.2%), Florida (2%) and Texas (1.8%).

During the COVID-19 pandemic, California's population dropped after a decade of steady growth. After reaching its highest-ever population level in 2020 with more than 39.5 million people, the state lost nearly 1% of its population by July 1, 2021, as it introduced a rash of restrictions, including the closures of offices, retail stores, restaurants and schools.

California is still the na-

Detectives lie to suspects in interrogations. Should they?

Experts question a method they say can lead to false confessions and wrongful convictions

By ANITA CHABRIA AND JESSICA GARRISON

Thomas Perez Jr. was hours into an interrogation by police about his missing father when they dropped some devastating news: A body had been found.

Thomas Perez Sr., they told his son, was dead.

The news crushed Perez, but he never considered that the authorities could be lying.

They were. The tale of his father on a gurney in the morgue was a deception used to push Perez to confess to killing him.

Over several more hours, interview transcripts show, detectives shut Perez down when, again and again, he told them he hadn't harmed anyone. Instead, they hammered him with accusations. Exhausted, in despair and desperate to stop the "pounding," Perez said later, he finally agreed with police that he had killed his father.

Then, he tried to hang himself using a shoelace — hours before his father was located, alive and well.

"They were not listening to me telling them the truth," Perez told Times reporters recently, trying to explain why he would falsely confess. "Their continual attack on me came to the point where I no longer wanted to tolerate it. I felt, 'I have to end this.'"

In their push to break down a man they suspected of being a killer, Fontana officers were drawing on the playbook of a combative and sometimes deceptive interrogation philosophy that has been widely embraced by police departments across the country for almost 80 years. It is a method that trains detectives to pursue a confession and be unrelenting in their questioning when they believe they have the guilty suspect, and even lie about evidence.

The method is so widespread that it has been glamorized in film and TV procedurals such as "Law and Order": A tough and driven detective goes into "the box," as interrogation rooms are sometimes called, and obtains a confession from a suspect through trickery or sheer force of will. Some policing experts say that, properly used, the method can elicit truth from criminals who are lying.

But increasingly, critics and criminal justice experts — including both law enforcement leaders and civil rights advocates — have raised concerns that the method, especially if deployed irresponsibly or to excess, can lead to

China's alleged 'long game' for influence in L.A. County, beyond

By RICHARD WINTON AND HANNAH FRY

It was no secret that authorities believed the Chinese government intended to infiltrate state and local governments across America.

For years, the FBI has warned cities and police agencies about foreign actors potentially trying to influence politics. Two years ago, U.S. intelligence officials issued a bulletin stating that the Chinese were collecting information about local officials.

Now, federal prosecutors allege that one Chinese spy operation was underway in the San Gabriel Valley, with the aim of gaining political allies to the country's cause.

The scope of the operation

remains unclear, but court documents and sources familiar with the inquiry said at least one local council member was caught up in the alleged scheme.

The indictment is more a window into routine municipal politics than the stuff of an international spy thriller.

But experts say the case sheds light on Chinese tactics and the scope of how Beijing is attempting to gain influence in America.

Horace Frank, the former assistant chief of the Los Angeles Police Department who oversaw the counterterrorism bureau, said the Chinese government understands that local politicians — even with their limited current roles — may rise to become more influential over time.

Committee accuses Gaetz of 'regularly' paying for sex

The House ethics panel's report says one of the recipients was a 17-year-old girl.

By FARNOUSH AMIRI AND LISA MASCARO

WASHINGTON — The House Ethics Committee on Monday accused Matt Gaetz of "regularly" paying for sex, including with a 17-year-old girl, and purchas-

ing and using illicit drugs as a member of Congress, as lawmakers released the conclusions of a nearly four-year investigation that helped sink his nomination for U.S. attorney general.

The 37-page report by the bipartisan panel includes explicit details of sex-filled parties and vacations that Gaetz, now 42, took part in while representing Florida's western panhandle.

Congressional investigators concluded that Gaetz violated multiple state laws



RICK SCUTERI Associated Press
EX-REP. Matt Gaetz denies any wrongdoing.

related to sexual misconduct while in office, though not federal sex trafficking laws. They also found that Gaetz "knowingly and willfully sought to impede and obstruct" the committee's work.

"The Committee determined there is substantial evidence that Representative Gaetz violated House Rules and other standards of conduct prohibiting prostitution, statutory rape, illicit drug use, impermissible

Biden spares 37 of 40 on death row

The president converts punishments to life imprisonment weeks before Trump's arrival. **NATION, A4**

L.A.'s messaging system under fire

Review looks into why chats involving City Hall staff were automatically deleted. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Google proposes antitrust fixes

A government "decree" would harm competition and the public, the tech giant says. **BUSINESS, A8**

Weather

Afternoon showers. L.A. Basin: 61/47. **B6**

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